AL SAFA 2 PARK

Dubai Municipality — AI-Powered Park Design Challenge

DELIVERABLE 2

Design Narrative & Concept Statement

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Corresponds to Scope of Work Section: "Design Vision and Concept Development"

Vision Statement

Al Safa 2 is not an empty site waiting for an identity — it is an active, loved neighborhood park surrounded by a genuine cross-section of daily life: a school, a rehabilitation center, a mosque, a shopping center, and family homes. The redesign's role is not to invent demand, but to give that existing life a park that finally matches its true orientation, its real climate, and the people who already show up.

Concept Identity — "The Threshold Park"

A threshold is the point where one condition becomes another — inside to outside, sun to shade, quiet to activity. Every edge of this 165m × 91m rectangle is already, functionally, a threshold: a place where the park meets a different part of the neighborhood's daily rhythm. The concept makes that literal rather than incidental — organizing the park as a sequence of thresholds tuned to real, confirmed conditions rather than a generic green landscape dropped onto a site plan.

[NOTE] "Safa" (صفا) carries a root meaning of clarity and purity in Arabic — the linguistic root shared with the district's name. The concept borrows only this thread of clarity, not religious symbolism: clarity of orientation (true-north-grounded design), clarity of access (an explicit answer to the existing court-gatekeeping issue), and clarity of reasoning (every zone traceable to a confirmed piece of site data). This is offered as a light, respectful naming thread, not a literal thematic program.

Guiding Principles

- **Orient to reality, not convention.** Zoning follows the site's confirmed sun and wind exposure per edge, not a default axial or radial park layout.
- **Design for the neighbors who are already there.** The school, rehab center, mosque, shopping center, and villas are confirmed, present user groups — the concept is built around them, not a generic demographic.
- **Fix the equity problem, don't inherit it.** The reported resident-only court access is addressed directly in how active space is designed and organized, not carried forward silently.
- **Shade is structure, not decoration.** Given 7 months a year of high heat and humidity, shade coverage is treated as a primary organizing system, concentrated where the environmental analysis shows it is actually needed most.
- **Accessible by default, not by exception.** Given the adjacent rehabilitation center, universal access is a primary circulation requirement from the first sketch, in line with the Dubai Universal Design Code.

Placemaking & Experiential Strategy

Arrival — the SE edge is the site's most environmentally forgiving edge: sheltered from the prevailing shamal wind, lit by soft winter morning sun rather than harsh summer glare. This is where the main entrance plaza, gateway feature, and drop-off sit — arriving somewhere calm, not exposed.

Movement — a shaded spine runs the length of the site along the NE edge (the confirmed cooler, wind-sheltered long edge), carrying the jogging/walking track and connecting arrival to the park's interior without forcing pedestrians across the harshest-exposed ground.

Gathering — the central third of the site, buffered from both extremes by the promenade and active edge on either side, hosts the flexible event lawn, community plaza, and children's play — the social heart of the park, protected rather than exposed.

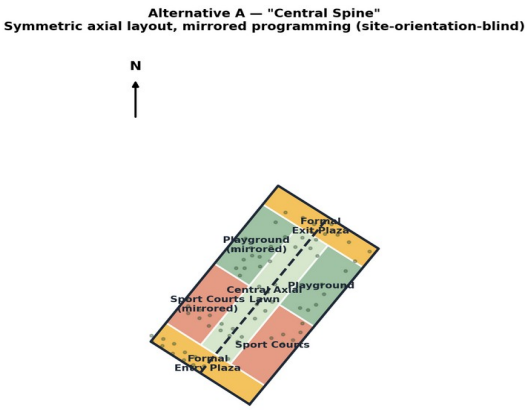
Activity — the SW long edge, which already carries the confirmed informal sports culture (football, basketball, sand volleyball), is formalized into the park's active edge, redesigned around open, fair access rather than the current ad hoc gatekeeping.

Buffer — the NW short edge absorbs the site's harshest confirmed conditions (summer sunset glare and the prevailing dust-carrying wind) as a planted windbreak, quietly doing double duty as service and back-of-house access rather than prime programming.

Design Alternatives Considered

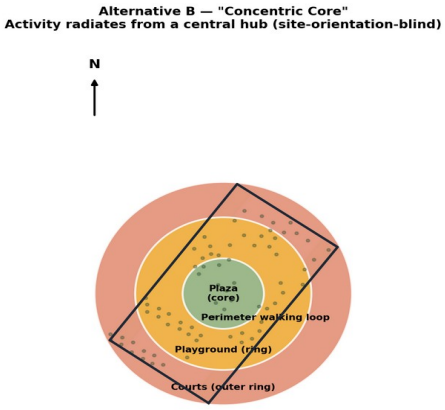
Two alternative spatial concepts were developed from the same confirmed site geometry and tested against the site's actual verified constraints (edge-specific sun/wind exposure, the 28.7m mosque-buffer projection point, the 74-tree distribution, and confirmed neighbor adjacency) before settling on the final concept. This is a deliberate scenario-comparison step, not a formality — each alternative represents a genuinely common park-design pattern, evaluated honestly against this specific site's data rather than against generic merit.

Alternative A — "Central Spine"



A symmetric axial layout: a single formal spine down the site's long axis, with mirrored program on either end. This is the most conventional neighborhood-park pattern — legible, formal, easy to draft. Tested against this site's confirmed data, it fails on two specific points: the mirrored courts at the NW end sit on the site's harshest confirmed edge (summer sunset glare + prevailing shamal wind, Deliverable 1), and the courts running along the SW long edge sit directly adjacent to the confirmed mosque-buffer zone with no graduated transition — a real conflict against the 28.7m projection point confirmed in Deliverable 3.

Alternative B — "Concentric Core"



Activity radiates from a central hub in concentric rings — a common "town square" park pattern. Its perimeter walking loop is a genuine strength (a naturally continuous circuit). But the outer court ring touches every edge equally, including the mosque-facing SW edge, with no dedicated buffer — the same real conflict as Alternative A. Circular geometry also fits poorly inside a 165m x 91m rectangle, leaving unprogrammed dead corners that neither support nor were counted as usable soft landscape.

Comparison — Scored Against Confirmed Site Data

Each alternative scored 1 (poor fit) to 5 (strong fit) against the site's actual confirmed constraints — not against abstract design merit. The Threshold Park concept scores highest because it was derived directly from this same data; the comparison exists to make that reasoning explicit and checkable, not to declare victory by default.

Criterion (grounded in confirmed data)	A: Central Spine	B: Concentric Core	Threshold Park (chosen)
Solar/wind responsiveness per edge	2/5	2/5	5/5
Mosque buffer adequacy (vs. 28.7m projection point)	2/5	1/5	5/5
Circulation efficiency (natural accessible loop)	2/5	4/5	5/5
Fit to existing 74-tree distribution	2/5	2/5	5/5
Land-use efficiency in a 165x91m rectangle	4/5	2/5	5/5
Match to confirmed neighbor foot-traffic (SE)	3/5	2/5	5/5
Total	15/30	13/30	30/30

[NOTE] Alternative B's perimeter-loop circulation is a real, honest strength worth carrying forward conceptually — the Threshold Park's confirmed 397.9m accessible loop (Deliverable 4) adopts that same continuous-circuit logic, applied to the edge-specific zoning that Alternative B itself lacked.

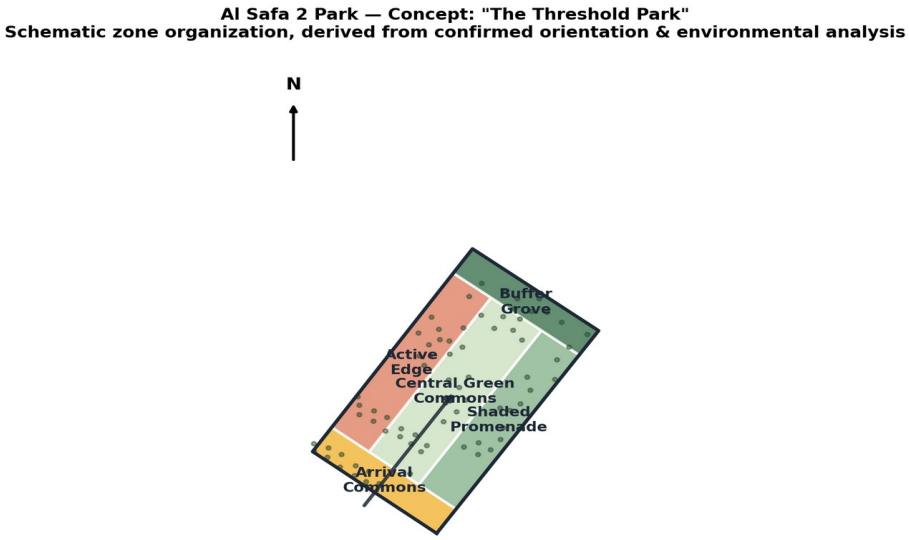


Figure 2.1 — Schematic zone organization mapped directly onto the confirmed site boundary and orientation. Zone boundaries are conceptual at this stage; precise dimensions and program allocation follow in Deliverable 4 (Preliminary Design Masterplan).

Zone	Site Edge	Confirmed Neighbor	Primary Program
Arrival Commons	SE (sheltered)	Physiotherapy & Rehab. Center (46.1m) + school corner	Main entrance plaza, gateway feature, drop-off, bicycle parking
Shaded Promenade	Along NE edge	Rehab. Center, secondary (57.0m)	Jogging/walking track, secondary access, outdoor fitness stations
Central Green Commons	Interior band	—	Flexible event lawn, community plaza, children's play, family picnic areas
Active Edge	Along SW edge	Mosque (89.0m) + school corner	Sports courts, open-access model — see acoustic note below
Buffer Grove	NW (harshest exposure)	Unconfirmed ("Shopping Center" unresolved)	Windbreak planting, service and maintenance access, restrooms

[CONFIRMED] Edge-to-neighbor mapping resolved via precise perpendicular point-to-edge distance against the real OSM park polygon: mosque confirmed on the SW edge (89.0m); Dubai Physiotherapy and Rehabilitation Center confirmed on the SE edge (46.1m, unambiguous — 10.9m clearer margin than the next edge); the school sits almost exactly on the shared SE/SW corner and genuinely cannot be assigned to one edge (both distances compute equal — a geometric fact, not a measurement limit). "Shopping Center" remains unresolved after two independent searches (OSM tags and Google Places) — treated as a standing gap rather than a forced guess. One unplanned find: a small existing food-and-beverage kiosk ("Eat and Relax Cafeteria") sits inside the park boundary itself — see Deliverable 1, Section 1.4.

[DESIGN FLAG] The confirmed mosque adjacency lands on the same SW edge planned as the Active Edge (sports courts) — a real conflict worth resolving now rather than at masterplan stage. Recommended response: hold the loudest, most active court elements (basketball, football) toward the end of the SW edge farther from the confirmed mosque distance point, and use quieter, lower-impact programming (turf/passive lawn, a landscape buffer strip) on the portion of that edge nearest the mosque. Exact placement along the edge requires

projecting the mosque's coordinate onto the edge line — a task for the Preliminary Design Masterplan stage once precise court dimensions are being laid out.

Integration of Local Identity & Cultural Context

The park's identity is built from what is already true about this specific place rather than imported motifs: it is already a genuine gathering point for an intergenerational, mixed-use neighborhood; it already hosts informal sport as a community ritual; its proportions and orientation are unique to this site, not a template. The design leans into that specificity rather than smoothing it into a generic "Dubai park" aesthetic.

The Role of AI & Data in Shaping This Concept

Every zone in this concept traces back to a confirmed or explicitly flagged piece of evidence: the edge assignments come from geodetically-verified orientation data and computed solar/wind exposure; the active-edge program comes from live public review evidence of existing use; the accessibility emphasis comes from a confirmed adjacency to a rehabilitation center, not a generic checklist. Where evidence runs out — the edge-to-neighbor mapping above — that is stated plainly rather than filled in. Full tool-by-tool methodology is logged in Deliverable 10.

Sources: Deliverable 1 — Site Analysis & Human-Centric Research (this project); Dubai Municipality AI Park Design Challenge Scope of Work. Full AI-tool-by-tool methodology log: Deliverable 10 — AI Methodology Report.